

The Stealth BOMBER

With 3,500 runs in all forms of the game in the last 18 months, the prolific left-hander from Delhi is on song

| By Sharda Ugra |

So Napier stunned everyone. A Test match to save, 10 hours and 43 minutes of batting, roots dug into the wicket, bat anchored to orthodoxy, eyes on nothing but the next ball. All this from a man with dancing feet and a swordsman's wrists. Not even a Michael Jackson Kathakali could have produced more slack jaws.

Actually, Napier stunned no one. No one who knows Gautam Gambhir well, that is. Michael Slater calls him the "Pocket Rocket" and on most days, Gambhir, 27, bats like his boots are on fire but the left-hander from Delhi has always moved to an inner music.

Not just Napier, but the form that has made Gambhir India's most improved batsman over the last 18 months comes from the same source as that innings in New Zealand—a deep, perennial stream of persistence that feeds into his self-belief. It is all well-disguised by Gambhir's heady, in-your-face batsmanship, swirling backlifts and rapier strokeplay. At full tilt, a plumed hat seems more suitable headgear than that blue helmet.

His batting may look cavalier but his numbers now are substantial, heavyweight. Since the start of the T20 World Cup in September 2007, he has scored 3,567 runs for India with nine centuries (1,587@69 in Tests, 1,652@42.35 in ODIs and 328@29.8 in T20s), four in Tests and five in ODIs, and 21 fifties. He won five Man of the

Match awards and was Man of the Series in New Zealand. It is as if he is making up for lost time in an international career that began as early as 2003 but had only consisted of a series of false starts until late 2007.

This run of form should give him a sense of security and a feeling of finally belonging to that elite dressing room. Far from it. "I don't want to think of 'belonging' because I still have a long way to go. I tend to put pressure on myself and feel that every time I have to bat, it has to count." India coach Gary Kirsten once told him, "never flirt with your form", so Gambhir, whom opening partner Virender Sehwag has called the next great Indian opener after Sunil Gavaskar, is trying to stay faithful to what he has learnt.

The prime lesson is that in cricket, runs and not words matter. The overwhelming argument of numbers is the batsman's only truth. Gambhir's runs in domestic cricket—9,100-plus runs and 29 centuries—have been a crowbar that forced the door open again. Over the course of 18 months, he has countered all criticism with the contrary proof of runs. Only a flashy 30s and 40s kind of player? This season he has scored five centuries in eight Tests @84 and one century and four fifties in 14 ODIs @45. Can only play weak opposition? Since September 2007, Gambhir averages above 45 against Australia, England, South

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Africa, New Zealand and Sri Lanka. Can only play at home? He has more centuries (six) away than at home (three), @ 47.73 in all forms of the game. The defence rests and so, you have to say, should the prosecution.

Outside the Indian team in the 2005 and 2006 period, Gambhir churned out the runs for Delhi and also worked in the nets with his coach Sanjay Bharadwaj. He tied a golf ball to a necktie in order to align his centre of gravity more securely. This to stop himself from falling over and playing across his front pad to balls coming into him. Bharadwaj's calculation of how long it took is not in hours or days but in "hundreds"—the number of times the correct stroke was repeated. He says, "Gautam has always faced struggles ever since he was an under-14 batsman but he's never given up."

When he got back to the team in England, former selector Sanjay Jagdale noticed a "different Gambhir,

